

Impact: Medium Difficulty: Easy Misuse risk: Medium

WHY IT WORKS

Generic praise is so common it no longer registers — specificity signals actual attention. When you name the exact behaviour you noticed, the person knows the compliment is real and it reinforces precisely what you want to see more of.

WHAT IT IS (AND ISN'T)

- Not flattery — flattery serves the speaker; a genuine compliment serves the person who did the thing.
- Not a softener for the criticism you are about to deliver — the sandwich teaches people to flinch at praise.
- It is evidence that you were paying attention, delivered with nothing attached.

THE PAYOFF

How it lands: Praise from you means something, because it is earned, specific, and free.

Principle: Specific praise is believed and remembered; generic praise is discounted on arrival.

What you gain

- Compliments that are trusted rather than decoded for motive
- More of the exact behaviour you named
- Goodwill that survives later disagreements
- A reputation for noticing, not just judging
- Relationships that warm without owing you anything

Why most people fail at it

- They stay generic — 'great job' — and it slides off without landing.
- They attach a request, and the praise becomes the price of the ask.
- They praise so often that each instance is worth less.
- They compliment the outcome when the skill was in the decision.

CORE FORMULA

Specific thing -> Why it stood out -> Stop

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Give one compliment today that names the specific thing you observed and why it mattered to you. Do not add qualifiers or requests after it.

BEST FOR

- Building trust and goodwill with colleagues
- Motivating people authentically
- Strengthening relationships without flattery
- After someone does good work, especially unnoticed work

METHOD, STEP BY STEP

1. Specific — Name the specific thing

Point at one observable moment — a sentence, a decision, an edit — rather than a trait. The narrower the target, the more believable the praise.

Trait: 'You are such a strong writer.'

Moment: 'That opening paragraph did the whole argument's work in three lines.'

2. Why — Say why it stood out

Add the one sentence that makes it yours: the effect it had on you, the room, or the work. This is what separates observation from throwaway politeness.

Unanchored: 'Nice presentation.'

Anchored: 'Your presentation is the reason the room stopped relitigating the decision.'

3. Stop — Stop — nothing attached

End the compliment where it ends. No request, no 'one small thing though', no pivot to the next agenda item in the same breath.

Attached: 'Great work on the deck — while I have you, can you redo the appendix?'

Clean: 'Great work on the deck — the flow especially. That is all I wanted to say.'

FIELD TIP

Name the moment, not the person.

'You are brilliant' asks them to believe a verdict; 'the way you paused before answering was brilliant' shows them what you saw. Praise aimed at a specific moment cannot be argued with — it happened, you noticed, and that is the whole message.

Situation: A colleague defused a tense client call this morning.

Don't: 'You are so good with people!'

Do: **'When you named the delay before they could raise it — that turned the whole call.'**

PHRASE BANK

Specific Praise · Naming the thing

- "The way you handled that question in the meeting was sharp."
- "That document was really well-structured — easy to follow."
- "I noticed how calm you stayed under pressure today."
- "The way you explained that to the client was exactly right."
- "You spotted something in the data that nobody else caught."
- "That was a good call — and I do not think it was easy to make."
- "The edit you made to that paragraph made it much clearer."
- "You handled that pushback with real composure."

Impact Phrases · Why it mattered

- "It made the difference in how the meeting landed."
- "That kind of thing does not go unnoticed."
- "I wanted to say it because I meant it."
- "I have been thinking about that since yesterday."
- "That is not a small thing — it takes skill."
- "That made my job easier and I wanted to acknowledge it."

Quick Compliments · Short, specific, in passing

- "Good catch on that error."
- "That subject line did all the work."
- "Nice framing in that email."
- "That was the right call at the right moment."
- "Clean handover — nothing missing."
- "You made that look easier than it was."

Professional Praise · Crediting work in work settings

- "Your analysis changed my mind on the timeline — I came in believing the opposite."
- "The rollout went smoothly because of the preparation, and I want that noted."
- "The way you structured that document saved the meeting twenty minutes."
- "That risk you flagged in March is exactly what just happened. Well called."
- "Your summary was the clearest statement of the problem I have heard so far."
- "The client asked who wrote the proposal. I made sure they knew."

Praise Under Pressure · Crediting people when it costs something

- "Before I push back on the plan: the thinking behind it is genuinely strong."
- "You are arguing against me and doing it well — that last point in particular lands."
- "I want to be clear in front of this room: that decision was theirs, and it was the right one."
- "I disagreed with you at the time. You were right, and the way you held your ground was impressive."
- "That was a hard message to deliver and you did it without flinching."
- "Credit where it is due, even though it weakens my case: your numbers are better than mine."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Generic: 'Great job today!'

Better: You did well in that meeting.

Best: The way you stayed calm when they pushed back — that changed the whole dynamic.

2. Weak: Compliment attached to a request

Better: You did great, and while I have you — could you...?

Best: Compliment on its own, request in a separate message.

3. Weak: Vague praise: 'You are really talented'

Better: Your presentation skills are strong.

Best: That opening line in your talk changed the energy in the room.

DECISION TREE

If You want to compliment someone but it feels generic

Name one specific thing. Drop the generic opener.

"That specific decision you made — the one about X — was really well-judged."

If You want to compliment and then ask for something

Give the compliment cleanly on its own. Make the ask separately and later.

"I just wanted to say that. No agenda — I'll follow up about the project separately."

If The person deflects or minimises your compliment

Gently hold the compliment.

"I know you will say it was nothing — I do not agree."

If You give a lot of compliments and they feel cheap

Give fewer. Choose the ones you actually mean.

"I do not say this often, but..."

SCENARIOS

Colleague who did unnoticed work well

Name the specific work and the impact it had. — "The report you put together — the structure made it really easy to use. I noticed."

Direct report who handled a difficult situation

Be specific about what they did and why it worked. — "The way you responded to that complaint was exactly right. I was impressed."

Manager who gave good feedback

Thank them specifically for what was useful. — "The feedback you gave last week on the proposal was genuinely helpful — especially the point about the opening."

Friend or partner who made an effort you noticed

Name the specific effort, not the result. — "I noticed you did X when you did not have to. I just wanted to say that."

WORKED EXAMPLE

Without the technique

You: Great job on that presentation!

Colleague: Thanks. (Uncertain what they did well, compliment fades quickly)

With the technique

You: The way you handled the pushback on slide 7 — staying calm and going straight to the data — that was exactly the right move.

Colleague: That moment was harder than it looked. Thank you for noticing.

COMMON MISTAKES

The compliment-sandwich

Sounds like: 'Great work — but the middle section needs redoing — but overall great!'

Better: Deliver praise and criticism in separate conversations, each allowed to land on its own.

Praise with an invoice attached

Sounds like: 'You are so good at this... which is why I volunteered you for the next one.'

Better: 'You are genuinely good at this.' Make the ask another day.

Complimenting the person instead of the work

Sounds like: 'You are amazing!'

Better: 'The way you re-ordered the argument made it twice as strong.'

Arguing with their deflection

Sounds like: 'No, seriously, you never give yourself credit, this is a whole thing with you...'

Better: 'I know you will wave it off. I still meant it.' Then let it rest.

Inflating it until it is unbelievable

Sounds like: 'That was the single best email I have ever read in my life.'

Better: 'That email was unusually clear — I noticed how little effort it took to act on.'

READING THE ROOM

Signs it is working

- People light up or seem genuinely touched.
- The compliment does not create awkwardness.
- You mean it — you are not performing praise.
- The relationship warms without any agenda.

Signs to adjust

- Compliments feel transactional or manipulative.
- You are giving praise to get something.
- The praise is so frequent it loses meaning.
- People do not believe you — your compliments are too broad.

WHEN NOT TO USE

- When you are fishing for a reciprocal compliment — the motive will be sensed.
- In formal performance reviews where specific praise can inadvertently exclude other positive qualities.
- When the compliment is about something outside the person's control rather than their choices or skill.

RECOVERY LINES

Best line: 'That sounded like the set-up for bad news. It was not — there is no second half.'

- "That came out as flattery — the real version is that I noticed one specific thing."
- "I tacked a request onto that, which cheapened it. The compliment stands on its own."
- "I said 'good job' and moved on, and it deserved better than that."
- "I realise I praised the result and skipped the part that was actually hard."
- "That sounded like the set-up for bad news. It was not — there is no second half."
- "I never said this at the time, so I am saying it late: that piece of work stayed with me."

TECHNIQUE CHAINS

Clean praise chain

Name the moment -> say why it mattered -> stop -> make any ask separately

The way you handled the pricing question was exactly right.

It kept the client in the room when we could easily have lost them.

That is all — no follow-up, I just wanted it said.

(The request about next week goes in a separate message.)

Deflection chain

Give the compliment -> let them wave it off -> hold it gently -> move on

That analysis changed the decision. That is rare.

(They wave it off.)

I know you will say anyone would have caught it. Nobody else did.

That is all — I just wanted you to hear it.

RELATED TECHNIQUES

TC013 — Name the Effort

Name the Effort is the sibling move — this card praises the quality of the work; that one honours what it cost.

TC025 — Shared Credit

Shared Credit scales the compliment to a room — naming exactly who did what in front of the people who matter.

TC008 — No-Overexplaining Discipline

No-Overexplaining Discipline is the 'stop' in the formula — a compliment padded with qualifiers stops being believed.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Noticing

Observe one thing today that someone does well. Write it down but do not say it yet.

Day 2 — The specific test

Give one compliment that includes a specific observed detail.

Day 3 — No agenda

Give one compliment with nothing attached — no ask, no follow-up, no transition to another topic.

Day 4 — Delayed delivery

Tell someone something you noticed about them last week or last month that you never said.

Day 5 — Written praise

Send one short written note complimenting something specific.

Day 6 — Public vs private

Decide whether the compliment is better said privately or in front of others. Say it accordingly.

Day 7 — Calibration

Did your compliments land well? Were any too vague? Did any feel forced or like performance?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I name the specific thing I observed — not just 'good job'?
- Did I say why it stood out to me?
- Did I stop after the compliment rather than add a request?
- Did I mean it — or was it a social lubricant?
- Did I avoid the compliment-sandwich (compliment-criticism-compliment)?
- Did the timing feel natural, not forced?
- Did I resist over-complimenting in a way that loses meaning?